LOCAL IS MOST VOCAL

al issues have taken centre stage again in the state



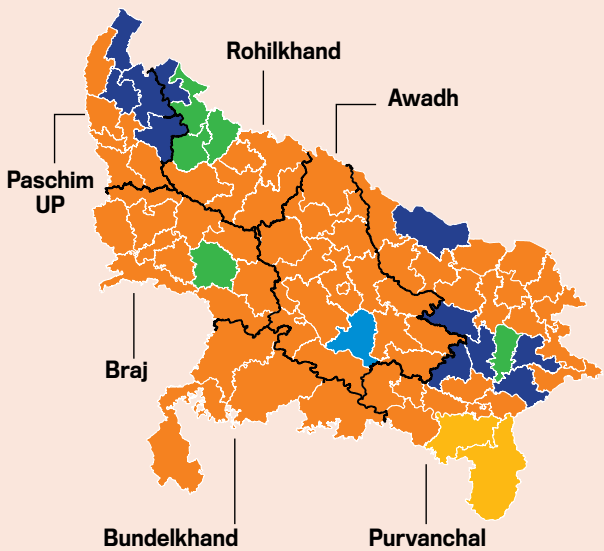
PTI

bloc claims it gave a good account of itself in the first phase.

The Jats make up about 15 per cent of the electorate in 10 LS seats in west UP. The Muslims (25 per cent), along with the Dalits, constitute half the electorate in the region. The RLD is contesting the Jat-dominated seats Baghpat and Bijnor this time, while the INDIA bloc is relying on Muslim-Yadav unity and local factors. Rajput anger against the "meagre representation" is one of them. The community makes up a sizeable 10 per cent of the vote in west UP, but were left with just one BJP ticket, Moradabad.

Key contests: In Muzaffarnagar, Union minister and controversial BJP leader Sanjeev Balyan is looking to make it three times in a row but faces a big challenge from SP candidate and former Rajya Sabha MP Harendra Malik. Rajput anger and Muslim vote consolidation could create problems.

In Nagina, Bhim Army chief and president of the Azad Samaj Party Chandrashekhar Azad was in a four-cornered fight, with the SP and the BSP also contesting.



2019 LOK SABHA RESULTS

BJP AD(S) BSP SP Cong. Others

BUNDELKHAND

Vital factor: Labharthis, the beneficiaries

SEATS: 5

A semi-arid region spread along the Madhya Pradesh border, Bundelkhand has been a BJP stronghold since 2014. The party has repeated its sitting MPs and is betting on its *labharthi* welfare schemes and the improved law and order situation to carry the day. The Opposition is wooing the non-Yadav OBCs (35 per cent of the voters) in this belt.

Key contest: In Jhansi, the BJP's Anurag Sharma is up against the Congress's Pradeep Aditya Jain, a former Union minister who won in 2009.

AWADH

Vital factors: Ram temple, Gandhis

SEATS: 23

Awadh region is considered the heart of UP. The seats in the region include Gandhi family bastions Raebareli and Amethi on one side and Ayodhya on the other. This is the first Lok Sabha election after the Ram temple consecration ceremony, so the BJP is relying heavily on the Mandir factor. After losing Amethi in 2019, **Rahul Gandhi** is contesting in Raebareli this time, replacing mother Sonia Gandhi, who is now an RS member. Family loyalist K.L. Sharma will be taking up cudgels in Amethi. Muslims make up 15-20 per cent of the region's voters, and elite castes and Dalits 25 per cent each. The rest are OBCs, mainly Yadavs and Kurmis.

Key contest: Rahul Gandhi had switched to the Raebareli seat after losing to Smriti Irani in 2019. The BJP fielded UP minister Dinesh Pratap here.



ANI